

How to Set Up a Content Gap Analysis

A content strategy is a game plan for marketers. And like any good gameplan, it requires studying your rivals.

The best way to do that is by creating a **content gap analysis**. Think of it as an audit for your industry. You collect a sample of content from a few relevant companies, organize the assets by a common variable, and calculate how engaging they were. Then, you chart the data to visualize trends and opportunities.

The goal of this worksheet is to help you analyze common trends and identify opportunities for creating unique content. The insights you glean from the gap analysis will guide decision-making and help you optimize your approach over time.

Before you start investing time and money to create content, you need to figure out what's worth creating in the first place. As hockey player Wayne Gretzky put it, "You want to skate to where the puck is going, not where it's been." Part of that strategy should include research that looks at what your competitors are doing in terms of topics, formats, channels, and more.

Another key point is that the competitors you choose to study don't necessarily have to be your main business rivals. They may include media companies or blogs that cover similar topics. Remember, consumers are looking for trustworthy information regardless of where it comes from.

As you begin outlining your gap analysis, the best variable to start with is topics. Committing to core topics will make it easier to sketch an editorial calendar, plan campaigns, and find the most qualified talent. However, what you think you need to create and what you actually should create may be different. You'd be surprised how often we fall back on our intuition instead of testing our beliefs.

Now, you can gather data and develop your gap analysis manually. There are also a handful of tools that'll make the process easier, some of which you can access through a free trial or freemium subscription. We're going to show you how different options work and break down a handful of tools worth exploring.

Let's get started.

PART I

Popular Gap Analysis Tools

BuzzSumo: Examines social engagement and social share data for individuals URLs. Offers a capped amount of free searches per month. Also has a Pro tool that costs money in exchange for more searches. Doesn't pull LinkedIn shares, but has a clear layout and reliable data. We recommend you start with this if you decide to use social engagement to rank competitors in your gap analysis

SEMRush: A variety of features that tracks everything from keyword rankings and backlinks to traffic and lead data. There's no free option. Least expensive option is a \$99/mo Pro package. You can use the platform to track your competitors in more specific metrics.

Moz: Focuses primarily on SEO performance and tracks data like page authority, domain authority, and more. Offers 10 free queries per month in addition to a suite of free SEO tools. Also advertises paid options for Moz Pro and Moz Local.

PART II

Google Sheet (Link)

Instructions to do a gap analysis on the number of stories per topic:

1. Identify three content competitors and enter their names in the tabs
2. Pick a number of shared topics relevant to each competitor and enter them into the column headers (start with 3-5)
3. Look at your competitors' sites over the last three months. Then fill out the columns in the spreadsheet for each piece of content. (Tip: Using a tool like BuzzSumo will make it easier to automatically filter data over a certain timeframe.)
4. In each tab, filter the "Topic" column in alphabetical order to group all content on each of the topics.
5. Calculate the number of stories for each topic. (ex. 14 stories about food)
6. Rank the number of stories per topic from your competitors and fill in the corresponding colors to your gap analysis grid.

Optional: Instructions to do a gap analysis on social engagements per topic:

1. Identify three content competitors and enter their names in the tabs
2. Pick a number of shared topics relevant to each competitor and enter them into the column headers (start with 3-5)
3. Look at your competitors' sites over the last three months. Then fill out the columns in the spreadsheet for each piece of content. (Tip: Using a tool like BuzzSumo will make it easier to automatically filter data over a certain range.)
4. In each tab, filter the "Topic" column in alphabetical order to group all content on each of the topics.
5. Using a tool like BuzzSumo, fill in the number of social engagements for each piece of content.
6. Add up the sum off all the social engagements for each topic (ex. 750 engagements for education, 571 engagements for school safety, etc.)
7. Rank the amount of coverage for each competitor and fill in the corresponding colors to your gap analysis grid.

PART III

Designing a Gap Analysis Grid

Below is an example of a blank grid designed to highlight white space opportunities. The bar on the bottom is a key for scoring content. Using the Google Sheet, look at the total number of social engagements each competitor has per topic. Then score each block. (Here, a dark blue box would signify a topic has already been covered a lot. A white or light color means there hasn't been as much coverage.)

	[Topic1]	[Topic2]	[Topic3]	[Topic4]	[Topic5]	[Topic6]	[Topic7]
YOUR COMPANY							
[COMPETITOR 1]							
[COMPETITOR 2]							
[COMPETITOR 3]							
[COMPETITOR 4]							

Low Coverage <1%	Medium Coverage 1-14%	High Coverage 15-50%	Very High Coverage 51-100%
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When you're finished ranking competitors by different topics and assigning each square a color, your grid should look something like this:

	[Topic1]	[Topic2]	[Topic3]	[Topic4]	[Topic5]	[Topic6]	[Topic7]
CUSTOMER NAME							
[COMP 1]							
[COMP 2]							
[COMP 3]							

Low Coverage <1%	Medium Coverage 1-14%	High Coverage 15-50%	Very High Coverage 51-100%
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By the end, you should be able to state a clear action item based on the white space. (ex. I have an opportunity to stand out by creating more content about Topic 5).